

Chicken Shawarma

Oil-based marinade · thin-sliced thighs · high-heat chop-and-sear finish

YIELD	ACTIVE	MARINATE	SPICE RATIO
900g · 4-6	~30 min	12-24 hr	2.5% meat wt

PART 1

SPICE BLEND

Makes ~50g — 22g into one 900g batch

Cumin	28%	14 g	Black pepper	7%	3.5 g
Coriander	18%	9 g	Cinnamon	5%	2.5 g
Paprika sweet	15%	7.5 g	Cardamom green, seeds only	3%	1.5 g
Turmeric	10%	5 g	Nutmeg	3%	1.5 g
Allspice signature	9%	4.5 g	Clove	2%	1 g

Grind everything together in a spice grinder to a uniform powder — whole spices ground fresh are far more potent than pre-ground (the volatile oils oxidize fast). Grind the whole spices first, then pulse the pre-ground ones (paprika, turmeric) in to homogenize. **Cardamom: green pods, seeds only** — the papery husk is flavorless filler; the 1.5g is seed weight. **Allspice is the signature note** — 9% is conservative, bump to **12-15%** if timid; **go easy on clove**, it dominates fast. Blend keeps **6+ months** sealed.

PART 2

MARINADE

Per 900g boneless skinless thighs

Chicken thighs boneless, skinless	900 g	Lemon juice (5-6%)	45-54 g
Spice blend (2.5%)	22 g	Garlic minced (3-4%)	27-36 g
Olive oil (15-20%)	135-180 g	Fine sea salt (1.5-2%)	14-18 g
		Onion grated (optional)	1/2

Why oil-based, not yogurt: oil carries the fat-soluble spice compounds *into* the meat. Yogurt forms a barrier — it seasons the coating, not the chicken. **Acid held to 5-6%:** thin slices absorb more, and excess acid turns the texture mushy. **Never exceed 48 hr** marinade — the acid degrades the protein.

TEMPERATURE TARGETS

IR gun confirms the surface — don't eyeball it

Pan/griddle surface (IR)	450-500°F	Chicken internal	165-175°F
Oil shimmer	visible waves	Char coverage	15-20%

Cook & Finish

PART 3

METHOD

Active ~30 min — serve immediately, no rest

- 1

Slice: trim fat, slice thighs horizontally to ¼" (6mm). Thin = complete flavor penetration — the whole reason the inside isn't bland.
- 2

Build: whisk oil, lemon, garlic, salt, and spices until **deeply tinted**. Taste — it should read aggressive; the meat tames it.
- 3

Marinate: coat every piece, bag or container, refrigerate **12–24 hr** (24 = full development). **Max 48 hr.**
- 4

Temper: pull from fridge **30 min early**. Heat **cast iron / flat-top griddle** until screaming hot — **IR-confirm 450–500°F**.
- 5

Sear: single-layer batches, 2–3 min/side for char. Let the surface recover between batches — **crowding = steam**, no char. Target 15–20% surface char.
- 6

Chop: all pieces back on the hot surface, chop with two spatulas, let sit **30–60 sec**, toss. Builds crispy edges.
- 7

Serve: immediately, no rest — crispy edges degrade fast. Pull at **165–175°F**. Taste before wrapping; it should eat great plain.

Chop-and-sear replicates the spit: a vertical shawarma spit does two things — bastes in rendered fat and chars on high heat. Thin slice + oil marinade + screaming-hot iron + the chop step reproduces both at home. **Flat-top advantage:** more surface = bigger single-layer batches without crowding, which is the #1 cause of no char.

TROUBLESHOOTING

PROBLEM	CAUSE	FIX
Bland inside	Slices too thick or under-marinated	Slice ¼" (6mm); full 24 hr marinade
No char	Surface too cool or overcrowded	Smaller batches; recover to 450–500°F
Dry meat	Overcooked or under-oiled marinade	Check 165–175°F; use 15–20% oil
Muted spice	Under-spiced	Scale to 3% meat wt; raise allspice
Mushy texture	Over 48 hr marinade or excess acid	Keep under 48 hr; hold lemon at 5–6%

SCALING

Hold the ratios — spice 2.5%, oil 15–20%, lemon 5–6%

1 LB (~450G)		3 LB (~1,360G)	
Spice blend	11 g	Spice blend	34 g
Olive oil	70 g	Olive oil	200 g
Lemon juice	25 g	Lemon juice	70 g
Garlic	15 g	Garlic	45 g
Salt	7 g	Salt	20 g